

Reddit as a Refuge for Managing Reproductive Rights in Post-Roe U.S.

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Abstract

Since the overturning of *Roe v. Wade*, accessing medication abortion in the U.S. has become increasingly difficult and, often, illegal. In this restrictive landscape, digital technology has emerged as a vital tool for self-managed abortion. Social media platforms like Reddit, particularly the subreddit *r/abortion*, serve as crucial spaces for accessing reliable information and sharing abortion experiences.

This paper explores the preliminary findings of our work on how *r/abortion* users share their experiences, construct personal narratives, and seek validation from the community. We thematically analyzed posts from October 2022 to October 2023, uncovering common themes. Our findings show that users share their stories to normalize their experiences, seek reassurance, and offer support to others in similar situations. From these findings, we discuss the unique role of online communities in a restrictive and oppressive social context.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

abortion access; reproductive rights; Reddit; reproductive health

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1 Introduction and Related Work

In the U.S., after the overturning of *Roe v. Wade*, which had ensured abortion as a right for all people, access to abortion has changed drastically, with some states imposing complete abortion bans [11]. This regulatory shift has resulted in a significant increase in people traveling out of state to seek an abortion [25] and in self-managed abortion (hereafter SMA) practices [24].

SMA refers to practices undertaken by individuals to end a pregnancy outside a formal or institutional healthcare facility [15]. Although SMA involves taking the same two medications, mifepristone and misoprostol [15], as an abortion performed in a formal

healthcare setting, it is often carried out without proper medical guidance or supervision, raising concerns about the safety and effectiveness of the procedure [10]. It has also been criminalized and prosecuted in several states in the U.S. [12].

On the other hand, many individuals prefer SMA because it helps protect their privacy [18], allowing them to seek an abortion without disclosing it to their community, partners, or family. Additionally, SMA is a more accessible option for those without medical insurance [14]. With digital tools, it has become even easier to have an SMA, as abortion seekers can search for and obtain the medication online from various websites [18]. However, this process does not come without challenges: due to the lack of formal medical support [10], people engaging in SMA often turn to online resources to obtain the help they need [21]. Unfortunately, some of these online resources may contribute to the spread of misinformation rather than providing reliable guidance [13]. Furthermore, given that abortion is a highly stigmatized topic [16] and now illegal in many states, finding accurate, unbiased information and discussing the topic freely has become increasingly challenging.

Research has long identified Reddit as a unique haven for open discussion on sensitive topics. Its affordances—such as pseudonymity, throwaway accounts [4], and easy access to niche communities [19]—make it a crucial space for discussing these topics and encourage disclosures that might not occur in real-life networks. On Reddit, people facing social stigma can find a sense of community, access shared experiences, and discuss highly stigmatized topics such as drug abuse [5, 6], sexual abuse [3], and intimate partner violence [7]. In these contexts, Reddit facilitates anonymous connections, offering both emotional and informational support to its users.

Reddit is also widely used by people navigating various aspects of reproductive health, such as pregnancy loss [2], postpartum depression [23], and polycystic ovary syndrome [9]. Research shows that online spaces are crucial for coping with grief, offering a sense of belonging and understanding [1]. Andalibi et al. [2] highlighted how individuals use Reddit to seek both informational validation (evidence-based or practical support) and experiential validation (connecting with others who share similar experiences), both of which help in sense-making and understanding the trauma of loss. Moreover, as social contexts become increasingly restrictive toward reproductive health, such as in the U.S. post-Roe, people perceive Reddit as a safe place where they can freely discuss their reproductive issues, make sense of their own reproductive bodies and health, and find protection from oppressive external forces [17, 26].

Abortion is highly discussed on Reddit, with most prior work focusing primarily on political discourse and general access to abortion care [22, 28, 29]. While this prior line of research demonstrates the crucial role Reddit plays in the abortion-seeking journey and

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the potential of using Reddit to explore the unique needs, concerns, and challenges faced by abortion seekers—both in-clinic and via SMA—in the U.S., there is limited understanding of how abortion seekers actively use Reddit to navigate legal and social barriers, seek accurate information, and find emotional support, particularly in the wake of increased restrictions. Moreover, prior work on online communities and stigmatized experiences [2, 3, 5, 6] suggests that online platforms serve as vital spaces for community building, sense-making, and navigating complex health decisions. However, abortion seekers' engagement with Reddit in terms of how they seek, share, and process information related to their care options remains underexplored.

Our research addresses these two knowledge gaps by posing the following research question: What types of information and support do individuals seek and share on Reddit regarding medication abortion in the U.S.? Specifically, we focus on uncovering the unique needs, concerns, and challenges of people seeking SMA and clinic-based abortions in the U.S. post-Roe. By scraping a year's worth of posts (October 2022–October 2023) from r/abortion and applying a reflexive thematic analysis, this poster presents preliminary findings, focusing solely on the analysis of posts (excluding comments) and using a single keyword to identify relevant discussions. Based on these findings, we offer novel insights into the evolving role of digital platforms in oppressive social contexts, contributing to prior work on understanding the role of online communities in reproductive care.

2 Methods

2.1 Data Collection, Data Analysis and Ethical Considerations

We focused on the largest English-speaking subreddit dedicated to abortion: r/abortion, with 52,000 members, used in prior work on similar topics [22]. After receiving ethical approval from our institution, we scraped posts that contained the term *abortion pill(s)* from October 2022 to October 2023. *Abortion pill(s)* was chosen as the keyword as it was identified by prior studies to be used by people when searching for information concerning abortion medication online [21]. Additionally, while in some communities people show evidence of self-censorship to avoid content moderation [20, 27], the community r/abortion is deliberate in encouraging people to create a stigma-free and pro-abortion space, wherein abortion experiences can be discussed openly by avoiding oblique terms.

This operation yielded 235 posts and 2183 comments, totaling 2418 elements. The data cleaning process involved removing all posts in which users mentioned seeking an abortion outside the U.S. (e.g., in the Philippines), resulting in a final dataset of 209 posts. We analyzed only these 209 posts using a reflexive thematic analysis method [8]. Because our focus was on understanding the needs of people who seek support, we only examined the posts and neglected the comments. Given the topic's sensitivity, we made some decisions to protect Reddit users' privacy: we respected Reddit's terms and conditions, we only scraped publicly available data, and finally, we rephrased the quotations presented in this manuscript. Two researchers participated in these coding sessions over 3 months; all researchers had prior experience in qualitative research and had conducted thematic analysis. During the coding process,

researchers completed an iterative, open, and axial coding process with each post being analyzed and coded by at least two researchers to ensure appropriate inter-coder reliability. The coding first started with familiarization with the dataset. Since *abortion pill(s)* can refer to both in-clinic procedures and SMA, we identified whether users explicitly mentioned seeking abortion through in-clinic settings or SMA. Further steps of our analysis included the formation of codes, generating themes, and evaluating them. Throughout the process, to ensure the robustness and reliability of our findings, we adhered to the best practices [8].

3 Results

As a first step, we identified all the posts that referred to an abortion performed in in-clinic settings and those referring to an SMA. SMA and in-clinic abortion involve taking mifepristone and misoprostol, with the major difference that for in-clinic abortion, this step is preceded by a doctor's appointment. A breakdown of all the posts about in-clinic setting abortion and SMA, and the three relevant themes, can be seen in Table 1. One key aspect that we noticed was the similarities between the categories across both dimensions; indeed, people who engage in SMA and people who sought an abortion in an in-clinic setting shared very similar worries and concerns. Hence, we decided to use the same three categories for both abortion modalities.

3.1 Users Seek Information and Advice for both SMA and In-Clinic Setting Procedure

The first theme that emerged from the dataset concerns the informational need expressed by abortion seekers on Reddit. Indeed, people seeking an SMA as well as people seeking an abortion within an in-clinic healthcare setting turn to Reddit to harvest accurate information and have their questions answered by the community. These questions can range from asking about the potential legal repercussions of doing an SMA *With all of the shit going down with abortion being illegal in Texas, is it still possible to order abortion pills from some website? Will my package somehow be discovered, and will I end up getting arrested or fined? (Post 92, SMA)*, as well as ways to get an abortion without their partners or the community knowing about it *I'm about 6/7 weeks pregnant and I need the abortion pill. I'm in PA and can't make it to a Planned Parenthood in person, so I need it have it another way. My husband won't allow for an abortion. We both work from home, so I can't make it to a clinic in person without getting him suspicious. How can I still do it? (Post 17, SMA)*. Finally, some of them ask the community to evaluate *Is this site (Aid Access.com) legit? I just got fired last week, so I don't have the \$800 to spend on an abortion right now. I wanted it done as soon as possible. (Post 100 SMA)* or to recommend legitimate websites that sell abortion medication without prescriptions *I'm in TX and want to order abortion pills, but all the websites look super sketchy and insecure. Does anyone have any recommendations for online abortion pills that ship to Texas? (Post 105, SMA)*. This reliance on the subreddit to collect abortion related information is not limited only to SMA, but it is applied to abortion done within in-clinic healthcare settings in states wherein abortion is legal.

My girlfriend and I have decided that taking the abortion pill is the best option considering our current life situations. Fortunately, we

Type of Post	SMA Count	In-Clinic Count
Seeking Information and Advice on Medication Abortion	63 (75%)	26 (20%)
Sharing Abortion Stories and Experiential Knowledge	14 (18%)	38 (30%)
Post-Abortion Experiences and Aftercare Concerns	6 (7%)	62 (50%)
Total	83 (100%)	126 (100%)

Table 1: Type of Posts for SMA and In-Clinic Settings Procedure

live in WA and can have them mailed to us because visiting a clinic is \$700. How stringent is the 10-week window? She stopped bleeding on June 22nd, putting her at 9 weeks 3 days as of today. Is there a no-cost option or assistance, for either telehealth or in-person, should we be outside the 10-week window? (Post 29, in-clinic settings). This shows the pivotal role of this subreddit as a reliable space in satisfying the informational needs of SMA abortion seekers, as well as those seeking medication abortion within an in-clinic health setting.

3.2 Users Share their Abortion Stories

A common theme across the dataset was users sharing with the communities their own abortion experiences, both self-managed and clinical. Drawing on Andalibi's framework of sense-making and emotional validation [2], we framed these abortion stories as users' ways of making sense of their abortion journeys and seeking validation from the community. These narratives help users process their emotions and connect with others, seeking experiential validation from the community *I need to talk about my abortion story. I don't want to be ashamed anymore. I know I don't owe anyone an explanation, but I want to talk about it. (Post 223, in-clinic setting).*

At the same time, users share their abortion stories as a way to counter a dominant narrative on abortion that reinforces the idea of abortion as a traumatic, horrific experience. Thus, by sharing their abortion stories, they advocate for normalizing abortion *I'm sharing my experience because for days before my appointment, I was reading so many terrifying stories about the abortion pill, and I was honestly so scared to go through with it. Mine was not bad at all compared to other people's, so I figured I'd share because everyone's experience is different, and it was not nearly as scary as I thought it was going to be. [...] I'm feeling regret and guilt over it, but I think that's normal, and I'm hoping it goes away over time. (Post 47, in-clinic setting).*

These narratives also serve as a source of guidance, with users sharing personal advice and recommendations. These stories are often deeply detailed, focusing on emotional and bodily changes throughout the process. By doing so, users provide a roadmap for others, helping them anticipate what to expect *I ended up ordering my pills online last minute (so much better and cheaper), and it only took a week to get to me. [...] Around 6 p.m., I started bleeding a bit; it wasn't cramping yet. Next thing you know, I'm gripping my counter while sitting on the toilet, literally with the worst diarrhea with clots that started coming out.[...] my experience was probably worse than others because I didn't take any pain medication prior, so, I recommend it (Post 194, SMA).* For some, sharing their story is also a way to give back to the community that supported them. *I can't thank this subreddit enough for being a source of information and support. The only way I can think of giving back is by sharing my story. (Post 207, SMA).* This reinforces how r/abortion serves

as a safe space where individuals can share, seek validation, and support one another without fear of judgment.

3.3 Post-Abortion Concerns are Common for both SMA and In-Clinic Setting Abortion Seekers.

Regardless of whether their abortion was self-managed or conducted in a clinical setting, many users seek advice on the aftermath of taking the medication required to have an abortion. This shows that their informational need concerning the aftermath of seeking an abortion is not completely satisfied by other external sources or actors. A recurring theme is the concern over whether their symptoms occurring after taking the medication are consistent with the procedure *I took my misoprostol dose about 4 hours ago, am having a lot of trouble finding reliable side effects online, and want to make sure I don't send myself into a crazy spiral. My cheeks and mouth are very sore—so sore that it hurts just for my teeth to brush naturally over the inside of my cheeks. I don't think I'm allergic to the drug—no tingling, no hives, no itching. I can't find anybody talking about this side effect—has anyone else experienced this? (Post 14, in-clinic setting).*

Even when abortions are conducted within formal clinical settings, many users turn to Reddit for post-procedure guidance rather than relying solely on healthcare professionals. *I decided to terminate my pregnancy via the abortion pill and took mifepristone earlier today. I wasn't spotting earlier in the day, but about 6 hours after taking it, I did start to bleed and clot heavily. I know the bleeding is normal, and they say it should feel like you're on your period, but is the clotting normal? Or should I be worried? (Post 206, in-clinic settings).* This section highlights a complex relationship between individuals and formal healthcare institutions, one characterized by distrust, unmet needs, or a sense that formal care does not adequately address the unique needs of the abortion process.

4 Discussion

This paper presents preliminary findings on the role of Reddit in supporting individuals seeking abortion in the U.S. post-Roe. Consistent with prior research on Reddit's role in stigmatized conditions [3, 5, 6] and reproductive health-related conditions [1, 2, 9, 23, 26], our analysis highlights how Reddit serves as a crucial resource for people navigating the complex experience of seeking an abortion. Importantly, in the context of increasing legal restrictions and social hostility toward reproductive rights, Reddit emerges as a critical safe space where individuals can access information, emotional support, and a sense of solidarity that might be otherwise inaccessible offline.

Our study reveals a novel insight as well: while SMA seekers rely on online spaces due to limited access to medical guidance, in-clinic abortion seekers turn to Reddit for support as well, filling gaps that formal medical care does not seem to address. Our findings show that both SMA and in-clinic abortion seekers share similar concerns about what to do before, during, and after the procedure. While prior research has established that SMA seekers face uncertainty due to a lack of medical oversight [10], it is new and unexpected that in-clinic abortion seekers also seek guidance on Reddit, particularly regarding side effects and post-abortion care. This challenges the assumption that in-clinic abortion provides sufficient support for individuals and highlights the unique role of Reddit in supplementing medical knowledge with peer-driven experiential information, especially in a climate where reproductive health care is increasingly policed and constrained.

Our study seems to suggest that Reddit offers a form of knowledge that extends beyond traditional medical guidance, and by doing so, it is widely used by people navigating the experience of seeking an abortion. Indeed, users turn to the platform for detailed, firsthand accounts of bodily sensations, side effects, and recovery experiences, information so rich in detail that it is often missing from formal medical sources. These rich, descriptive narratives, which might be dismissed in clinical settings as overly specific or unnecessary, help individuals better prepare for and navigate the abortion process. Additionally, Reddit fulfills an emotional need that medical care often overlooks. Unlike clinical settings, where the focus is on procedural facts, Reddit provides a space where abortion seekers can process their experiences emotionally. This finding builds upon prior work on sensemaking in stigmatized health experiences [1, 2], and further demonstrates how Reddit's collective affordances enable the creation of alternative, experiential forms of knowledge [26] that empower individuals navigating highly politicized and stigmatized healthcare journeys.

Additionally, Reddit plays a critical role in helping users assess the legitimacy and credibility of online sources selling abortion medications. In an environment where abortion pills are increasingly accessed online and where websites range from safe and reliable to fraudulent or dangerous [21], users rely on this collectively created knowledge to navigate the possible alternatives and make decisions informed by the community. This finding highlights the community's potential to help people make more informed decisions, while also demonstrating the risk of spreading inaccurate medical information and/or harmful advice.

Furthermore, the anonymity that Reddit provides plays a crucial role in encouraging individuals to disclose personal experiences. Many users, whether undergoing SMA or in-clinic procedures, choose to share their abortion stories in great detail, contributing to a collective knowledge that others can rely on. This process, driven by network-level reciprocal disclosure [1], helps individuals make sense of their own experiences and contributes to creating new narratives about seeking an abortion that combat the dominant view of abortion as a traumatic, horrific experience. By sharing their stories, users are actively engaging in the dual process of normalizing abortion and constructing a lived, bottom-up form of reproductive health knowledge. This dynamic highlights the

critical role of peer-driven online communities like Reddit in resisting oppressive reproductive regimes and providing alternative infrastructures of care.

5 Conclusion

In the context of growing restrictions and stigma around abortion in the U.S., Reddit offers a vital alternative support infrastructure. This paper presents preliminary findings from ongoing research on Reddit's role for abortion seekers, highlighting how the platform provides essential resources and support often unavailable elsewhere.

This study is characterized by several limitations, making it an initial exploration. The first concerns the choice of only one keyword to identify relevant content. We acknowledge that by doing so, we might have overlooked valuable insights and experiences, and that our dataset does not represent the entirety of the conversations related to abortion. In future work, we aim to expand our data collection methods. Additionally, we analyzed only the posts and not the comments, which may limit our understanding of how the community supports information seeking. We plan to include comments in our future analysis. Finally, future work should focus on abortion-seeking experiences from both patient and provider perspectives to develop a more holistic understanding of this reproductive health experience.

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